

BLACKBELT ON AGENTIC ABM — MEGABRAIN ACADEMY — MODULE 1

1. Fundamentals of ABM

A history of B2B sales and marketing, why inbound alone breaks down for enterprise accounts, and what ABM actually is.

1.1 A short history of B2B sales and marketing

Snake-oil, pyramid
& trust selling

1860s-1920s



Segmentation &
brand-based selling

1920s



Strategic Selling, SPIN,
first CRM, Value-added

1978-2000

Inbound: SEO, content,
marketing automation

2010s

1995

MEDDIC
qualification

2011

Challenger Sale &
Predictable Revenue



1886

N.C.R. — pyramid
selling



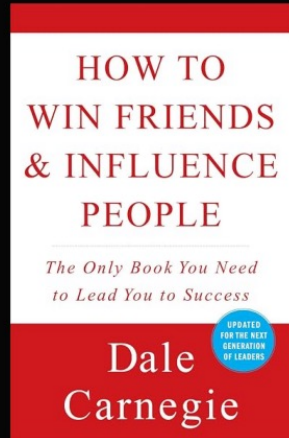
1930s-1970s

Barrier, mood &
need-satisfaction selling

1978 Strategic Selling -> 1986-88 first CRM & SPIN -> 1991-2000 value-added & Solution Selling -> 2010s inbound stack -> 2011 Challenger Sale & Predictable Revenue

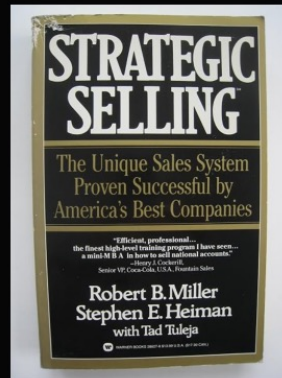
The books behind this module

1936



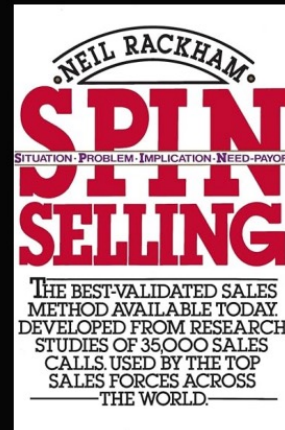
How to Win Friends and Influence People

1978



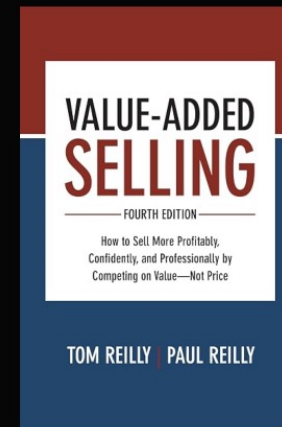
Strategic Selling

1988



SPIN Selling

1991



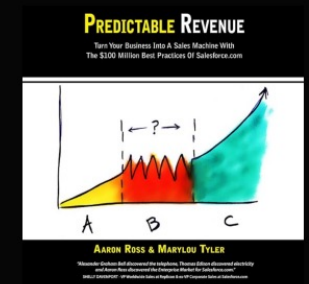
Value-Added Selling

2011



The Challenger Sale

2011



Predictable Revenue

Six books that mark the timeline above — worth reading in full if any single node above changed how you think about a deal.

1.2

Why inbound alone breaks down for enterprise accounts

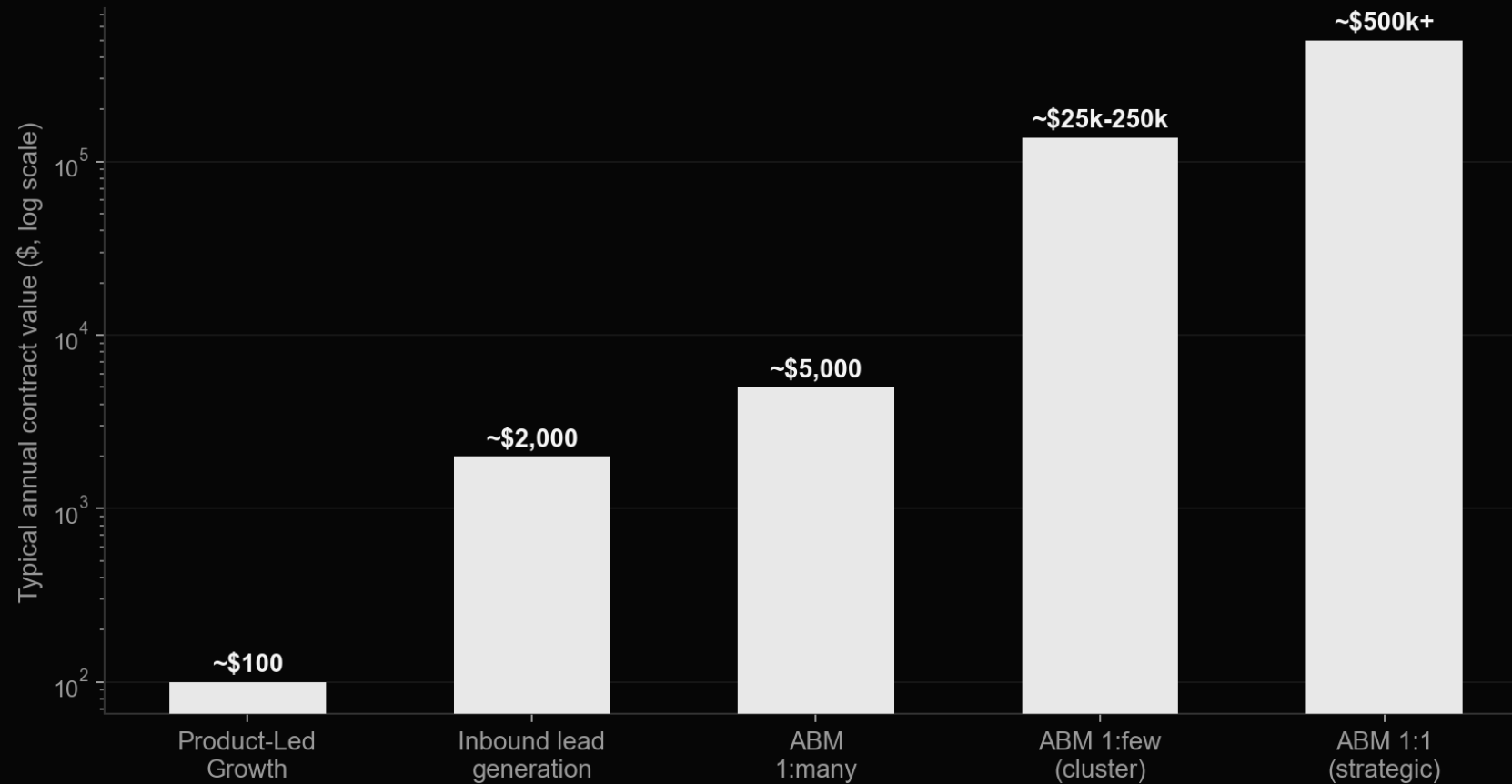
The real buying group is 5-15 people across departments. One scored lead is a poor proxy for account readiness — and "spray and pray" is a luxury you don't have when the addressable list is short.



In-class exercise: spot the CTAs

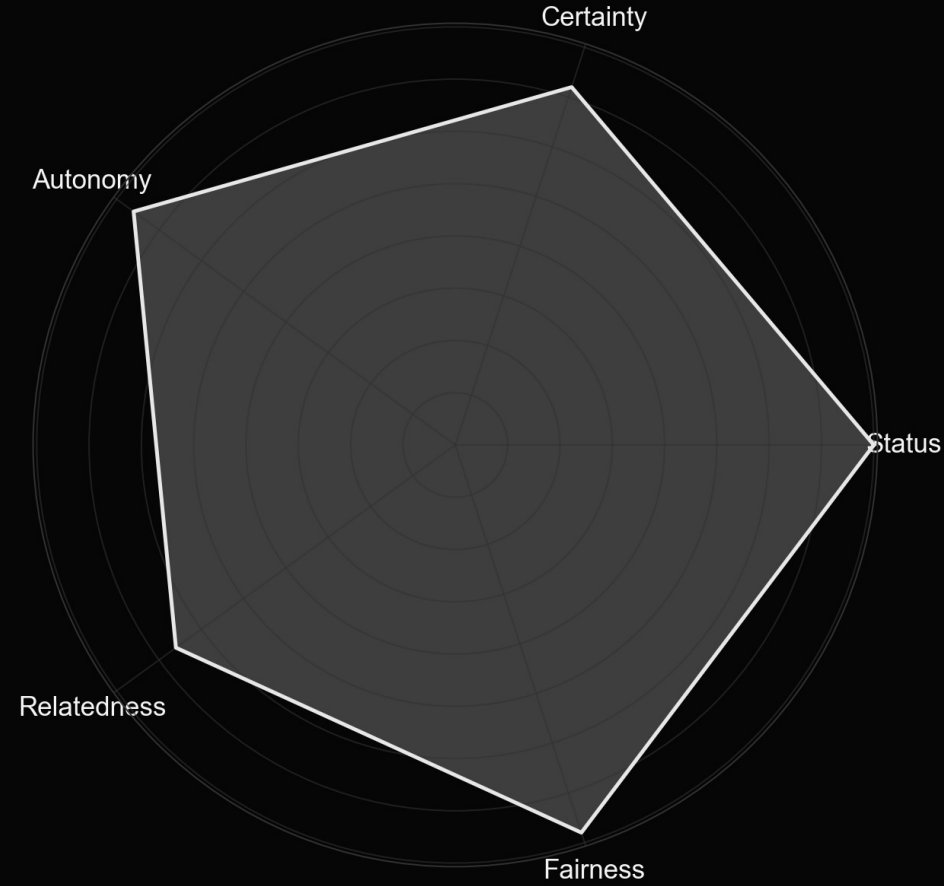
- B2B buying can look a lot like courtship — the "marriage" is a signed six- or seven-figure contract
- Open each site fresh and time-box 3 minutes per site: monday.com, Gong.io, Datadog, ZoomInfo, Grainger.com, CrowdStrike
- Count every call-to-action you can find — buttons, banners, exit-intent popups, chat prompts
- Which CTAs are "soft" (content, newsletter) vs. "hard" (book a demo, talk to sales)?
- Which of these companies looks ready to be nurtured, and which looks like it expects a hard pitch on visit one?

Go-to-market motions, by contract size



Contract size and account count should tell you which motion you're running — not the other way around.

SCARF: five levers of the threat/reward response



David Rock, 2009 — Status, Certainty, Autonomy, Relatedness, Fairness. Don't design only for the rational reading of a deal.

1.3

What Account-Based Marketing is

A customer-centric go-to-market model: marketing and sales work as one team against a defined account or micro-segment — multi-threaded and personalized by tier, not funneled one lead at a time.



The account journey

MB



Channels: social selling, direct mail, 1:1 events, C-level roundtables, business breakfasts, video — alongside email and advertising.

1.4 Three tiers of ABM program

1:1 Strategic (1-10 accounts) & ABM Lite (10-50)

- 1:1 — bespoke programs run like a dedicated micro-business unit per account
- OneLogin: goals -> ICP -> tiering -> personas -> sales content -> weekly monitoring
- Schneider: LinkedIn group + co-branded report as the wedge
- Trelleborg: content plan with SMEs — 5,216 landing visits, \$6M pipeline
- Boon Edam: scripted multi-touch — social touch, 3D mailer, call, exec breakfast, audit

ABM Programmatic (50-500 accounts)

Intent data and account-based advertising replace hand-built sequences. Example: a real-estate research program moved 570 accounts through a landing page, a business breakfast (96 attendees), and two follow-up webinars (80 / 60 attendees).



ABM-programmatic stack, by demand stage

TARGETED DEMAND	LinkedIn Sales Navigator	ZoomInfo	Crunchbase	Dealfront (ex-Echobot)
ACTIVE DEMAND	6sense	Bombora	Cyance	Breeze Intel. (ex-Clearbit)
ENGAGED DEMAND	RollWorks	LinkedIn (social selling)	Sendoso	Emissary
PRIORITIZED DEMAND	Uberflip	Salesloft	ActiveCampaign	Vidyard
DEAL FUNNEL / CLOSE	Cvent	Zoom	BrightTALK	1mind (ex-Drift)

Updated for July 2026: Echobot is now Dealfront, Clearbit is now Breeze Intelligence (HubSpot), and Drift is being sunset in favor of 1mind.

In-class exercise: is this ABM, or just good outbound?

- Scenario: a business-lending fintech runs a cold outreach campaign — a list of 4,000 companies, one email template with {{company_name}} merge tags, sent by 6 SDRs, no shared target-account list between marketing and sales
- Question 1: is this ABM? Walk it through the three diagnostic questions from 1.4 — named finite list? personalization past the merge tag? marketing and sales coordinated on the same accounts?
- Question 2: why is the verdict "no" — and what's the one change that would make it a real (if lightweight) ABM motion?
- Question 3: what's still useful about this campaign, even though it isn't ABM?

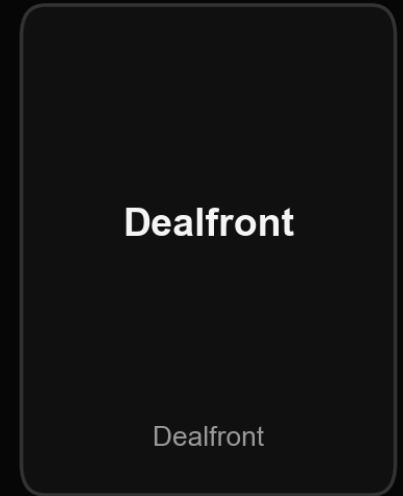
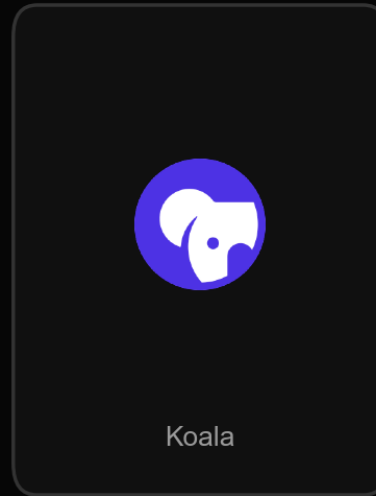
1.5

Where ABM meets inbound

De-anonymize which company is visiting, not the individual, and route the signal into the ABM motion.

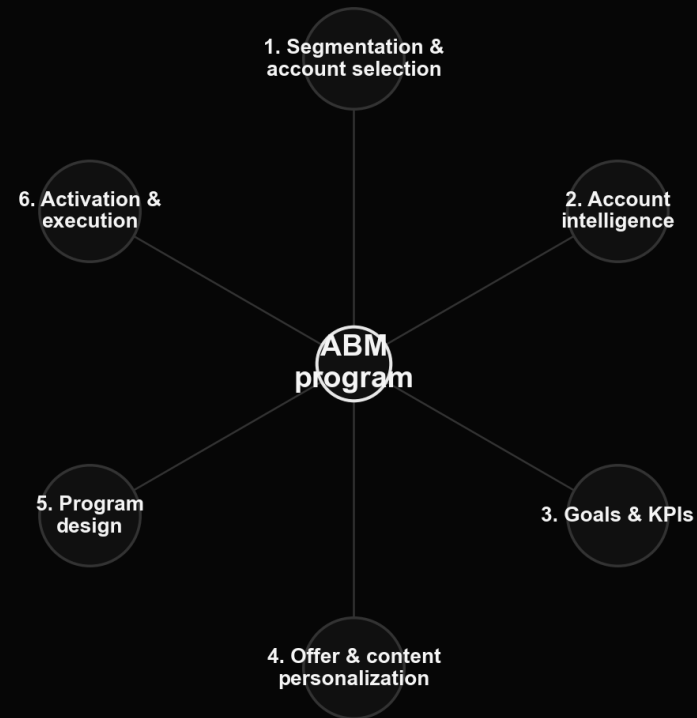


Website visitor identification tools



Also referenced in class: Factors.ai. All five resolve an anonymous visit to a company — none of them identify the individual.

The six ABM processes



Everything after Module 1 is one of these six, run roughly in order and then repeated as the program matures.

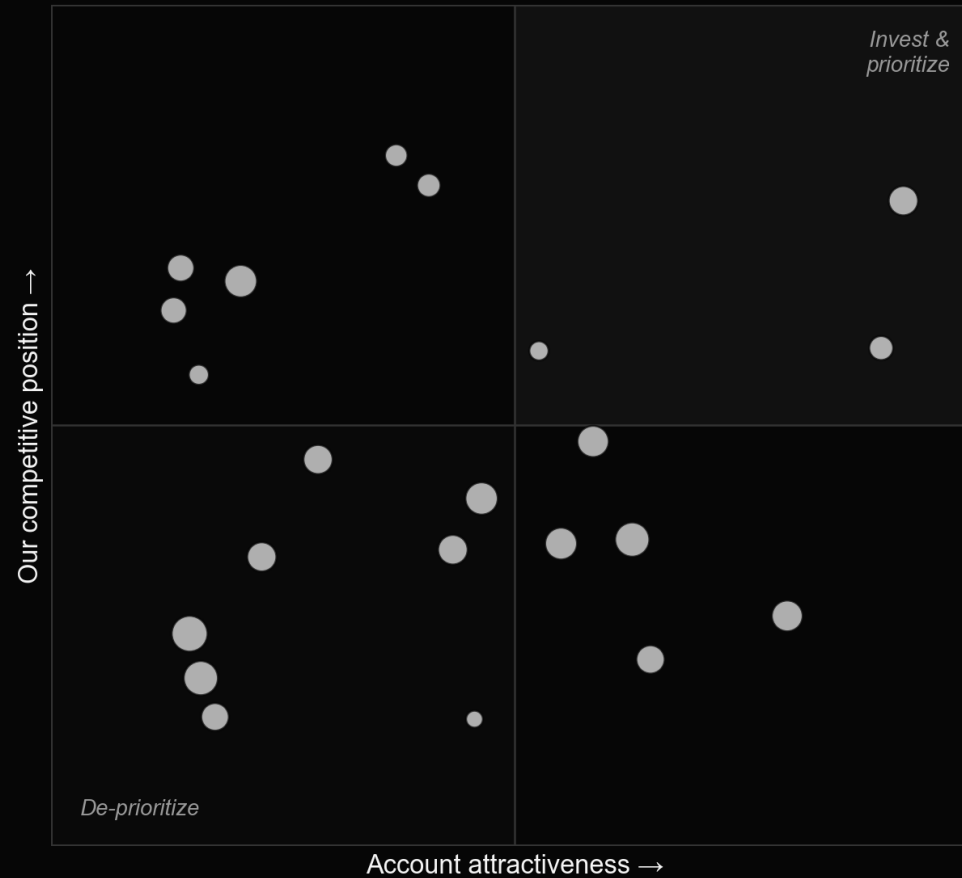
1.8

Worked example: scoring & shortlisting

A B2B shared-services provider scores ~25 candidate accounts on a GE/McKinsey-style 2x2 and cuts the list to a named shortlist. (Anonymized — the original used a real client's account list and included real personal contact data, not reproduced here.)

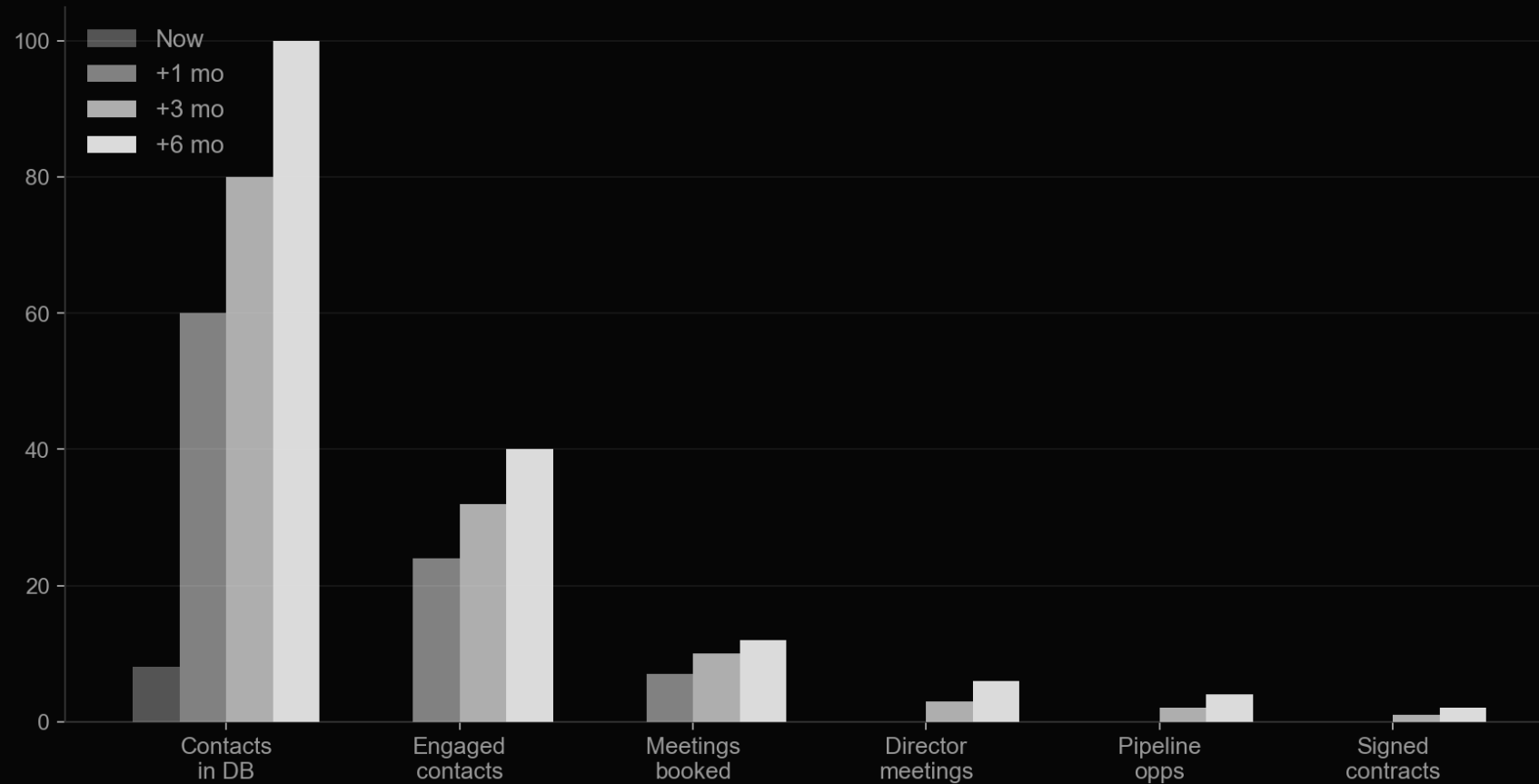


Scoring matrix: attractiveness vs. competitive position



~25 candidate accounts plotted; top-right quadrant becomes the shortlist.

KPI plan for a 20-account strategic program



Tracked now / +1 month / +3 months / +6 months, from contacts in database through signed contracts.

1.9 Agentic ABM in practice

MegaBrain: an agent workflow for this module



Point MegaBrain's desktop app at your account list, and one prompt — "should we even run ABM here" — turns into a scored recommendation and a first-draft business case, written straight into your files — no separate research tool, no API to wire up.

Other agent tools for the fundamentals stage

Clay — pull firmographic/technographic data to sanity-check your GTM-tier math. Perplexity / deep-research agents — summarize a market's B2B sales evolution and comparable ABM case studies. Make / n8n — a scheduled job that drafts a weekly "is this still working" pulse report. Relevance AI — stand up a lightweight research agent with no code.



The wider sales tech landscape — July 2026

Sales tech landscape — July 2026

Email Finder #1 Lemlist #2 FullEnrich #3 Clay	Email Sender #1 Expandi #2 Instantly #3 Lemlist	Multichannel Outreach #1 Lemlist #2 Expandi #3 Artisan	LinkedIn Automation #1 Lemlist #2 HeyReach #3 MirrorProfiles
Visitor Identification #1 Fastbase #2 VisitorQueue #3 Snitcher	Waterfall Enrichment #1 Clay #2 Lemlist #3 BetterContact	Technology Lookup #1 Clay #2 PredictLeads #3 TheirStack	Email Verification #1 Lemlist #2 Enrow #3 Zerobounce
Deliverability Infra. #1 Instantly #2 Mailforge #3 Mailreef	Workflow Automation #1 Lemlist #2 Relevance AI #3 Artisan	CRMs #1 Breakcold #2 HubSpot #3 Pipedrive	Sales Assistant (AI) #1 Sybill #2 Jason AI SDR #3 Veloxly
Account Research #1 CompanyEnrich #2 Lavareach #3 Databook	Sales Reporting #1 Databox #2 Quarrio #3 Signal	Video Outreach #1 Ubieque #2 BHuman #3 Pitchlane	E-Meeting #1 lemcal #2 Calendly #3 Praiz

Top-ranked tool per category, sourced from coldiq.com/tools. The category list, not any single vendor, is the durable part — this list will look different again in a year.

Exercises

Homework 1 — best and worst customers

- Pull a list of your existing (not target) customers' domain names — start from your CRM or billing system, not memory
- Rank them best-to-worst by feel, not a formula: revenue, low support burden, how much you enjoy working with them
- Write down the best 10-15, then keep going past them until quality clearly drops off — mark that cutoff line
- Repeat the same ranking exercise for your worst 10-15 existing customers
- Bring both lists to Module 2 — they become the seed data for your Ideal Customer Profile

Homework 2 — website visitor identification

- Pick one company-level visitor-ID tool (HubSpot, Factors.ai, Albacross, Dealfront, or Koala — see 1.5)
- Install its tracking script on your site and let it run for at least a full week of real traffic
- Calculate what share of total visitors it actually resolves to a named company
- Of the resolved companies, flag which ones look like attractive target accounts, and write down why

Homework 3 — LinkedIn Sales Navigator

- Start a free trial at linkedin.com/sales/onboarding and complete the setup
- Build one saved account search and one saved lead search matching the customer profile from Homework 1
- You'll use this trial directly for account and stakeholder research in Module 3

Homework 4 — set up MegaBrain

- Create a free account at getmegabrain.com — no credit card required, free models are available immediately
- Sign in, connect your GitHub account, and open a repo or folder to work in
- This account is required, not optional — Module 5's content and personalization exercises are built around it